Perceptions of Healthy Partner and Relationship Characteristics among Adolescents

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Background

- Adolescents receive little guidance from adults on how to define and develop healthy relationships (Noonan & Charles, 2009).
- Characteristics of healthy relationships include reciprocal communication, managing uncomfortable emotions such as anger and jealousy, and mutual respect (CDC, 2012).
- Understanding what adolescents consider to be healthy and unhealthy can inform future health promotion efforts.

Research Question

- To what extent are adolescents' stated qualities of ideal partners and relationships consistent with what health professionals define as healthy?

Methodology

- Data was obtained from a larger set of comments made by teens on an interactive website, TeensTalkHealth (Brady et al., 2012).
- Teens were recruited from local clinics and schools.
- The present study focuses on one discussion topic, *Perfect Partner*, which included the following questions:
  - Describe your idea of a perfect partner. What qualities are most important in a person you want to be in a relationship with? List as many as you want to.
  - Why do you think some people accept someone who is less than ideal? Is that being realistic, or is that settling for less than you deserve? How do you know?

- Fifty-five ethnically diverse teens aged 14-18 commented.
- Comments were coded into themes and subthemes using N-VIVO, specialized software for organizing qualitative data.

Results

Foundation for a Healthy Relationship

A partner should be…
- sensitive, compassionate, expressive
- supportive
- thoughtful, considerate
- understanding, caring, loving
- someone who loves me for me
- attracted to me and likes me
- a friend to me
- someone I feel comfortable around
- honest, trustworthy, not a liar
- loyal, reliable, committed
- not jealous
- not pushy, controlling
- respectful
- supportive of my independence

A relationship should be built on…
- loving each other
- respecting each other
- trusting each other

Healthy Communication Patterns

A partner should be…
- appreciative, thankful
- willing to listen and talk

A relationship should be built on…
- reciprocal communication
- working it out

Activities & Expression of Affection

A partner should like to…
- have fun, make me happy and smile
- do nothing together with me
- cuddle, kiss, hug

A relationship should be built on…
- having fun together
- lovingly touching each other
- sexual compatibility with each other

TRiO
RONALD E. McNAIR POST-BACCALAUREATE ACHIEVEMENT PROGRAM

Why Do People Settle?

Reasons For Settling

"…some ppl settle for less because they feel they cant do better some do it because they feel that that person can change i did it because he showed me the good side before i had to find out the bad …"

"…because they're scared to let them know, or they're abusive. i think that's settling for less because in the end your not happy with your love life…"

"... I think most people accept someone who doesn't deserve them just because they like feeling wanted and don't want to be alone."

"... People accept someone who is less than ideal for many reasons, whether it be looks, personality, love. I think it's most definitely settling for less than you deserve because we could do a lot better but we want what's in front of us in the moment so that we aren't alone and feel emotions of love and acceptance."

"…sometimes people settle for less because they just want to be loved. And it sucks when that happens."

Advocating for Healthy Relationships

"…If the guy/girl is not caring about you, listening to you, etc etc, then you know you're settling for less than you deserve, and NOBODY should settle for less than they deserve."

"…I feel that you do need to be realistic, but you shouldn't let yourself settle to someone who doesn't meet your minimum criteria. Relationships shouldn't be negativity."

"…everyone should be with someone that they are entirely comfortable with, and being with anyone else is settling for less."

"…sometime just settling for someone that seems "good enough" is the same thing as settling for less than they deserve."

Limitations

- The 55 teens who commented on *Perfect Partner* may not be representative of all teens who attended clinics and schools.
- Teens were not asked to visit the topic multiple times, making it difficult to obtain further thoughts.

Discussion

- Adolescents' stated qualities of ideal partners and relationships were consistent with what health professionals define as healthy.
- Teens discussed several reasons for settling, including a partner showing the good before the bad, being abused, thinking they could change a partner, not wanting to feel alone, and wanting to feel loved and accepted.
  - These factors should be the focus of targeted interventions.
- Some adolescents were adamant that no one should settle for less than what he or she views as important.
  - These teens implied everyone deserves a healthy relationship.

Conclusions

- The present research may aid in developing programs to help adolescents identify and build components of healthy relationships.
- Teens who advocate for healthy relationships may be valuable resources in designing and delivering health promotion programs.

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